were several such pieces of secret pride in the Soviet storerooms, he said, one such was the KVD-1 cryogenic engine.

'What's the specific impulse of this KVD-1 engine?' I asked, unable to hide my curiosity at the mention of the word 'cryogenic'.

'The specific impulse is,' the Russian paused, '461 seconds'.

We all knew that the Americans and the Russians were in a space race, the latest being in the development of cryogenic engines. Cryogenics, the science of extreme low temperatures, has been a tricky thing to master, and the two countries had achieved quite a few breakthroughs. Like the space-faring giants the US and the USSR, India—which had just put its first satellite Aryabhatta in space with Russia's help—had realised that only cryogenic engines could power rockets to take heavier satellites and make farther explorations in space. The specific impulse of an engine, broadly speaking, defines its strength. The Americans had developed engines with lesser specific impulse. Russians were great engineers—and much more amiable towards Indians than the Americans were—but they having developed anything better than the Amercan cryogenic engine sounded farfetched.

'You must be joking,' I told him, trying to make it sound more like banter than an argument. The Russian wasn't amused. He gulped down the soup, looked me in the eye with the same calmness he had the moment before he invited me for dinner, and said, 'Come to Russia, and I will show you.'

It was a new beginning of a friendship between two countries that later fired India's cryogenic dreams. Eighteen years later, when the Kerala police came knocking at my door in Thiruvananthapuram, that dream was threatened. I was to be branded a spy who sold rocket engine secrets to Pakistan through women spies from the Maldives—a conspiracy that would be eventually defeated, but not before dampening India's space dreams and virtually demolishing my life.

But India's space ambitions, fuelled by such greats as Vikram Sarabhai and Satish Dhawan, would overcome the *agnipariksha*, as time proved. Curiously enough, it took another eighteen years for me to prove my